A NEW VIGOUR FOR THE NEP

The considerable loss in learning during the pandemic slowed the New Education Policy. Only a fresh impetus can undo the damage

By Kaushik Deka

THE EDUCATION SECTOR was one of the worst hit by the pandemic. In a demographically young country like India, that meant tens of millions of young lives that revolved around education disrupted, as schools and colleges were shut for most part of the past two years. The effects—academic and psychological—are far-reaching. The Annual Status of Education Report (ASER), 2021 published by the NGO Pratham found that children's foundational reading and arithmetic levels have dropped substantially between 2018 and 2021. While the pandemic accelerated adoption of digital technology for education, socio-economic disparity and poor infrastructure forced dropouts, widening the learning gap among students. This has made implementation of the National Education Policy, aimed at ushering in a radical overhaul of the education system, more challenging.

In fact, the NEP, launched in 2020, says: "The highest priority... will be to achieve universal foundational literacy and numeracy in primary school by 2025. The rest of this policy will become relevant...only if this most basic learning requirement is achieved." The education ministry has taken steps to bridge the gap, including a learning assessment survey and schemes like NIPUN Bharat and STARS (Implementation of Strengthening Teaching-Learning and Results for States) and expanding digital infrastructure. The University Grants Commission has initiated reforms in sync with the NEP. However, the sector saw no significant increase in budgetary funds. In FY22, it saw a drop by eight per cent. In the current fiscal, it has gone above the pre-pandemic level. ■



WHAT'S DONE

- New Education Policy launched in 2020
- STARS project with aid from World Bank launched, and is expected to improve monitoring of activities in schools
- Other initiatives like Balavatika for universal access to early childhood care & education, NIPUN Bharat for students till grade 3, and art-integrated education, toy-based pedagogy being adopted
- Assessment framework for large-scale survey of students' learning outcome developed by NCERT
- Higher education institutions allowed to run full-fledged online courses
- Other initiatives include four-year degree courses, multiple entry and exit, academic credit, change in Ph.D. norms, incentives for foreign universities and students, single entrance test for central universities